

# PLANT NAMES AND ORIGINS

Plants have always been given local names, with the result that many of them were called by a different name in different regions and countries. To overcome this problem, a common naming system was devised and developed into the plant naming system that is now used worldwide.

## The binomial system

Greek and Roman scholars laid the foundations of our method of naming plants, but the binomial system used today was largely established in the 18th century by Swedish botanist Carl Linnaeus (1707–1778). Linnaeus classified each plant with two Latin words, rather than the descriptive phrases used previously. The first word describes the genus (eg. *Ilex*) and the second the epithet (eg. *aquifolium*). Together they provided a name for a particular plant species such as *Ilex aquifolium* (English holly). Other species in the same genus were given different epithets such as *Ilex crenata* and *Ilex serrata*. The system has been developed by scientists so that the entire plant kingdom is divided into a universally recognized “family tree” (see opposite).

## The meaning of plant names

Plant names are derived from various sources. Some are commemorative—the *Fuchsia* is a tribute to German physician Leonhart Fuchs—while others indicate a plant’s geographic origins, as with *Parrotia persica* (of Persia). A plant may be named after the collector who introduced it, such as *Primula forrestii*, cultivated by George Forrest. Alternatively, the name may describe the plant’s characteristics, for example, *quinquefolia* in *Parthenocissus quinquefolia*, which means with foliage made up of five leaflets; it comes from the Latin *quinque* (five) and *folium* (leaf).

A plant name may change either because the plant has been incorrectly identified; or because it has been given an earlier name; or because the name has been

found to apply to two different plants; or because new knowledge changes the plant’s classification. In this book, synonyms are included so renamed plants can be easily recognized.

## Common names

Although many plants have familiar common names, botanical names are used because not all plants possess a common name, or they may share a name with other plants. In addition, a common name may be used in different regions to describe different plants. For example, in Scotland “plane” refers to *Acer pseudoplatanus* (sycamore); in England it refers to the London plane (*Platanus x hispanica*), and in America both “plane” and “sycamore” are used for (*Platanus occidentalis*). Common names may also refer to unrelated plants as is the case with sea holly (*Eryngium*), hollyhock (*Alcea*), and summer holly (*Arctostaphylos diversifolia*), none of which is a true holly (*Ilex*). Another problem is that one plant may have several common names: heartsease, love-in-idleness, and Johnny-jump-up all refer to *Viola tricolor*.

## Botanical divisions

Divided into a hierarchy, plants are classified according to the following groups, which help to identify them:

### The family

Plants are grouped in families according to the structure of their flowers, fruits, and other organs. Families may consist of clearly related plants, such as orchids (family Orchidaceae), or embrace diverse plants as in the family Rosaceae: *Alchemilla*, *Cotoneaster*, *Crataegus*, *Malus*, *Geum*, *Prunus*, *Pyracantha*, *Sorbus*, and *Spiraea*.

### The genus and its species

A family may contain one genus (for example, *Eucryphia* is the only genus in the family Eucryphiaceae) or many—the daisy family Compositae has more than 1,000 genera.

Each genus comprises related plants, such as oaks (genus *Quercus*) or lilies (genus *Lilium*), that have several features



**ABOVE Wild origins**

Many plant species that subsequently become garden plants are initially found in the wild. The North Cape Province of South Africa is home to many annuals and succulents, from which breeders have produced new cultivars and hybrids.

in common, and a genus may contain one or a large number species. For example, a member of the genus *Lilium* could be any lily, but *Lilium candidum* denotes just one type.

A species is a group of plants that consistently and naturally reproduce themselves, often by seed or vegetatively, generating plant populations that share similar characteristics.

## Subspecies, varieties, and forms

In the wild, even plants of the same species can exhibit slight differences, and these are split into three subdivisions:

- The subspecies (subsp.) is a distinct variant of the species.
- The variety (var.) differs slightly in its botanical structure.
- The form (f.) has only minor variations, such as the habit or color of leaf, flower, or fruit.

## WHAT IS “OF GARDENS”?

The epithet “of gardens” is added to names that have been wrongly applied to plants in cultivation—that is, the plant has been misidentified because of its similarity to another plant. It can also be used for plants that have not yet been formally named, such as a hybrid that has arisen in cultivation.